

The Hollow Crown of Vehl

a series in ten books

BOOK I

The Eighth Ash

— Chapter Three —

CHAPTER III

The Reliquary That Did Not Belong to Its Saint

The drop into the lower passage was eleven feet.

Kael learned this the way he learned most things, which was after the fact: his tail uncoiled in measured handspans against the upper rim of the hatch, lowered him at a rate it had apparently decided was correct, and set him down on cold worked stone with such gentleness that he had time, on the way down, to revise his estimate of the tail's intelligence upward by a considerable margin. The tail, he thought, was either smarter than he was, or it was being directed by something else.

He filed both options and stood up.

The lower passage was different. The chamber above had been the work of a stoneworker paid in gold and threats; this place had been built by hands that had not

been paid at all. The walls were the same black basalt, but the dressing was sloppy here, the joints poured with a grey-white mortar that had wept in long lines down the stone like tears that had set. The ceiling was lower. The floor was dry. The air smelled, still, of nothing — that absence-of-smell he had marked above as uncommon in catacombs.

He understood the absence now. There was nothing alive down here. There had not been, he suspected, anything alive down here for a very long time.

Aren Mosk landed behind him with the cracking thud of a man who had jumped because he did not know how to climb. He landed badly. He went to one knee and made a small sound between his teeth and stayed on the one knee for several seconds before he found the energy to remember the water-skin slung across his back and the book clutched against his chest. He did not drop the book. Kael noted this and gave him, internally, a single mark of grudging credit. A man with bloody hands who clutched a book through a fall was a

man who had been taught that books were worth more than hands.

"Up," Kael said, in the chittering wrong voice that was not yet less wrong but was perhaps becoming his.

Aren Mosk got up.

Kael had not, on the way down, expected to be able to see. The torches above had been arterial red and the chamber here had no torches at all. He could see anyway. Whatever the Imp's eyes were doing now — and the Ledger, when he turned the smallest sliver of attention toward it, identified the faculty as Debt-Sight, level one, passive, the same line he had read four times already — was producing for him a picture of the lower passage in the color of a slow-burning candle. Everything in the room had a faint inner glow, dimmer or brighter according to laws he had not yet worked out, and the strongest glow was coming from a low arched doorway at the far end of the passage, perhaps thirty feet down.

He turned his head, slowly, in the new way that had become his way of looking at things, and he listed what else was glowing.

The mortar in the walls glowed faintly. The stone did not.

The water in Aren Mosk's water-skin glowed considerably, a soft amber.

The blood drying on Aren Mosk's hands glowed brighter than the water.

The book Aren Mosk carried glowed in two colors — a deep cool blue at the pages, and a thin red along the spine, as though two different inks had been used to write two different parts of it.

And on Kael's own small purple chest, the seven silver sigils he had earlier learned were called the body-wards glowed white. The five that were still active glowed steadily. The two that had broken did not glow at all; they were small grey scars now, the silver burned

out of them.

"What am I seeing," he said, not to Aren Mosk but to the Ledger.

The Ledger answered.

You are seeing debts in their accounting form. What glows holds a balance not yet settled.

Water holds the debt of its container. Blood holds the debt of its body. The book holds the debts of two writers. Your wards hold the debts of the man who carved them, who is dead and unable to release them. They will fade in time.

This faculty is called Debt-Sight. You possess it at level one. It will sharpen with use and with rank.

Kael read this and felt, for the first time since waking, something almost like gratitude. The Ledger was teaching him. The Ledger had not, in the chamber above, taught him anything; it had only reported. Down here, in the silence that had begun at the hatch, it had quietly shifted register. It was answering questions before he asked them properly. It had given him a definition. It had given him the *name* of the thing he

was doing.

He thought, very carefully, with a fraction of his attention dedicated to keeping his expression — to the degree that his small wrong face had expressions yet — even: Why now.

The Ledger did not answer that.

He filed the silence.

"Aren Mosk," he said. "The arch at the end of this passage."

The cultist looked. "Yes."

"That is the reliquary."

"Yes."

"You told me earlier that the reliquary was warded against entrance from below."

"Yes."

"We are below it."

A long pause. Aren Mosk's grey eyes moved across the dark passage and found, eventually, that he was not in fact below the reliquary — he was, by the geometry of the dais and the angle of the hatch, *level* with it, the hatch having descended only one floor and not two. He had said two earlier, in the chamber, because two had been the answer he had been told. He had not personally walked it.

"I — I was wrong. We are level with it. I'm sorry. The Brother said two levels —"

"The Brother said many things. We will, going forward, assume the Brother said all of them for reasons that are not the reasons he gave." Kael paused. "Is it warded against entrance from this side."

"I don't know."

"Useful. We will find out. Walk in front of me."

Aren Mosk walked in front of him.

The passage was longer than Kael had thought from the hatch — distance was, he was discovering, another variable his new eyes had not yet calibrated for. They covered the thirty feet in perhaps a minute, because Aren Mosk was walking like a man with one good knee and Kael was walking with the gait of a creature whose tail he had not yet stopped having to think about. By the time they reached the arch, Kael had revised his outside window from thirty-eight minutes to thirty-two.

The arch was not warded.

He saw this with the new sight. There were sigils carved into the lintel of the arch and into the stones of the threshold, three at the head and one in the floor, but four of them were burned out — dark grey scars, the silver fled. Only one sigil still glowed, and it was a small one set into the right-hand side of the threshold at knee-height, and it was not a ward of denial. It was, when Kael turned his attention to it, the Ledger volunteered a label.

Sigil identified: Ash-Witness anchor.

Function: marks the reliquary as known to a higher-tier
Candidate.

The mark is roughly six weeks old.

A Candidate of Stage 5 or higher has been in this room
before you.

Kael stopped walking.

He stood three paces from the arch and he read the line three times, and his small purple hand, of its own accord, came up and pressed against his small purple sternum where the heartbeat of the Ledger sat, and he thought: somebody got here first.

He had been told, an hour ago in subjective time, that there were eight Candidates. He had assumed, in the way he assumed most things — provisionally, with a default toward worst case — that the other seven were doing what he was doing: waking, surviving, learning their bodies. The Ledger had described one of them as already at Stage 6, the Hollow Prince, "ascending fast." He had filed that line and not yet costed it. He had not, until this moment, imagined the world of his new life as

containing other minds already several moves ahead of him on a board he had not yet seen.

He understood now. Six weeks ago, somebody at Stage 5 had walked into this room, had touched the right-hand stone of the threshold, and had marked the reliquary as known to them.

The cult had not summoned him into virgin territory. The cult had summoned him into a room where the furniture had already been counted by someone else.

He thought, very carefully: We are not the first. We are very late.

He looked at Aren Mosk. The cultist was watching him. The cultist had not seen the sigil — could not see it — but he had seen Kael stop, and he had read, with the dull exhausted attention of a man whose nervous system had been running too hot for too long, that the stopping meant something.

"What," Aren Mosk said. Just the word. Not a question.
A flag.

"The reliquary has been visited," Kael said. "Recently.
By something the Brother did not send."

The cultist's grey eyes widened a fraction.

"Walk in," Kael said.

Aren Mosk walked in.

The reliquary was a small room. Twelve feet across, perhaps. Round, not square — the only round room Kael had seen so far in this complex, which meant something, though he did not yet know what. The ceiling was a low dome. Set into the curve of the wall, at chest height for a man and well above Kael's, were seven niches. Each niche was the size of a small head. Each niche was carved with the same care that had built the chamber above, careful and well-paid; whoever had laid the lower passage had not been the same hands that had built this small round room.

Six niches were empty.

The seventh was not.

Aren Mosk stopped two paces inside the doorway and made a sound — a small involuntary intake of breath that was not, Kael thought, fear. It was the wrong texture for fear. It was the sound a man makes when he sees the place where a thing he believed should be is, in fact, gone.

"It's still there," Aren Mosk said.

Kael walked past him.

He had to crane his small head all the way back to see the niches properly. He could see only the bottom rims of them from his height; he could not, without climbing, see what was in them. He went, by instinct and by elimination, to the niche Aren Mosk had been looking at. Its bottom rim was, like the others, dressed dark stone. There was no light from it. The Debt-Sight gave him nothing.

He looked at Aren Mosk. "Lift me."

The cultist hesitated. He had clearly not yet imagined a future in which he would be required to put his bloody hands on the body of the creature he had helped summon. He hesitated for perhaps two seconds, and Kael let him have the two seconds, because two seconds for a man like Aren Mosk was the difference between a thing done from terror and a thing done from understanding, and Kael preferred, when he could afford it, to be obeyed from understanding.

Aren Mosk knelt.

He set the book down on the floor with the care of a man setting down a sleeping child. He moved his hands toward Kael — bloody, callused, the fingers long — and he paused, with the hands a few inches from Kael's small ribcage, in the way that small children paused before touching a museum exhibit they had been told was very old.

"You will not drop me," Kael said.

"No."

"You will not squeeze."

"No."

"You will lift me to the niche, and you will hold me there until I tell you to set me down."

"Yes."

Aren Mosk lifted Kael.

Kael had not, in any of the long careful inventories he had taken since waking, registered fully what his new body weighed. He weighed almost nothing. Aren Mosk lifted him as a man lifted a cat that had grown accustomed to being lifted, and he raised Kael to the niche, and he held him there with his bloody hands cupped lightly under the small thin armpits of the small new body, and his hands did not, in any way, squeeze.

Kael did not register the touch as an indignity. He registered it as data. The man's grip was even on both

sides. The hands trembled slightly but not from fear; from blood loss and exhaustion. The man's breath, four inches from Kael's small ear, smelled of the lead sigilist's salt-fire and of an old, embarrassed kind of unwashed sweat. Aren Mosk was, Kael decided, doing his best.

The niche, at his small face's height, was lit from within by a deep and waterless blue.

In the niche was a bone.

It was a finger bone. Smallest of the three bones of a human little finger — the distal phalanx, the tip — Kael had not, until he saw it, realized that he could name human bones, but the years of insurance-medical-actuarial reading had apparently lodged the vocabulary in him sturdier than he had guessed. It was old. It was the color of weak tea. It sat on a small black cushion that had once been velvet and was now mostly the memory of velvet, and it glowed with a slow inner light that was not its own.

Beside it, on the cushion, was a folded piece of paper.

The piece of paper was new. The paper was the only new thing in the room. It glowed faintly — not blue like the bone, not red like the book's spine, but a quiet pale yellow that suggested, when Kael narrowed his attention, that the debt the paper held was small and personal and not very old.

"Aren Mosk," Kael said, in the same conversational chitter he had perfected over the last hour. "You told me, in the chamber, that the cult came down here three weeks ago to take a bone. A bone of a saint."

"Yes."

"You took a bone."

"Yes."

"You took a bone from this room."

"Yes."

"From which niche."

A pause. "From — from this one. The seventh. The one we used. The Brother said the saint's body was scattered across seven reliquaries and that this room held the seventh part, and that we needed the seventh because. Because of the eighth."

"Because the body of a saint can anchor the summoning of a Candidate."

A swallow. "Yes."

"You took it."

"We — yes, we took it. I was there. I held the door. I —"

"You took a bone," Kael said, and the conversational chitter had no edge in it, and that was the worst possible edge a man could be on the other side of, "from this niche. Which means this niche should be empty. And it is not."

Aren Mosk went perfectly still.

He could feel it, Kael saw. He could not see the bone with his ordinary eyes — Aren Mosk was a journeyman and a journeyman's Debt-Sight was a thing he had read about and had not been initiated into — but he could see, from the angle of Kael's small head, that Kael was looking at a niche that contained something, and he had been told that the niche contained nothing. Aren Mosk made, very carefully, the sound that a man makes when he is trying to keep a thought small enough to not be heard.

He said: "Then. Then the Brother lied. Again."

"Or."

The cultist's grey eyes flicked.

"Or," Kael said, "someone came down here in the last three weeks and put a bone back."

The silence in the reliquary went very flat.

Kael reached, with the small new hand whose claws he was still learning, and he picked up the folded piece of

paper from the cushion. He did not, yet, touch the bone. The bone was glowing in a way he did not yet understand and he was disinclined to put his hand on anything that the Ledger had not described to him.

The paper was very thin. He unfolded it slowly. The folds had been made with the precise sharpness of someone who folded paper professionally, who had made this kind of fold so often that the folding had stopped requiring thought. The handwriting on the paper was small and slanting and — Kael saw at once, the way he had seen earlier on the margins of the book — the handwriting of the second annotator. The same hand. The hand that had written "if seven is who I think seven is then we have all been used."

The note said:

The seventh anchor was never here. The thing the cult will take from this niche on the fifteenth of this month is a substitute, carved by my own hand from the relic of an unaligned saint. The substitute will hold for one

summoning. After that it will fail. If you are reading this, the substitute is in your possession, or in the possession of the thing it summoned. The true seventh anchor is at the place we agreed on. I cannot write it here.

If you are the Eighth, and you are reading this: I am sorry. I did not know how to warn you any other way.

— S.

Kael read the note three times.

He read it the first time for information. He read it the second time for cadence. He read it the third time for what was not in it, which was the longest of the three readings and yielded the most.

What was not in it: any indication that S. was loyal to the Brother. Any indication that S. was loyal to the cult. Any indication that S. expected this note to be read by anyone except, specifically, the thing the cult had summoned. Any indication that S. expected to be alive

when it was read.

What was in it: a confession of forgery. A claim of foreknowledge. An apology made directly to him.

He folded the note again. He folded it badly — his small claws did not fold the way human hands folded — but he folded it tightly enough to hold, and he tucked it carefully into the soft crease between his collarbone and his shoulder, where the small new body had a flap of loose skin that seemed to function as a pouch. He had not, until that moment, known he had a pouch.

The Ledger, behind his eye, made a small unobtrusive note.

New debt held by you.

One letter, from S., a warning the writer expected would arrive after she could no longer help you.

Weight: substantial.

The Ledger does not yet know what to make of "I am sorry."

The line is held open.

She, Kael thought. The Ledger had said *she*.

He filed this with the precision of a man dropping a single bead on an abacus. The Ledger had, on its own initiative, identified the gender of the second annotator. The Ledger had not been asked. The Ledger had decided that this fact was load-bearing.

He set both observations down beside the others — the Ledger has opinions, the Ledger considers some debts substantial, the Ledger speaks to him by choice — and turned his attention to the bone.

He did not pick it up. He looked at it. He held his small clawed hand a finger's-width above it. The Debt-Sight gave him the bone in much sharper detail at close range: he could see, when he looked, that the inner glow was not coming from inside the bone at all. The bone itself was as dark as the velvet beneath it. The glow was a thin shell around the bone, perhaps a millimeter deep, the way a window-frosting catches at the surface and goes no deeper. The bone was wearing the glow the way a man wore a coat. The coat was not the man.

Kael, who had once spent six months as a college student picking through the actuarial records of an insurance scam in Osaka, recognized at once what he was looking at.

The bone was a forgery.

Whoever S. was, she had taken a finger bone from some other body — some unaligned saint, she had written, which Kael chose to read at face value for now — and she had layered debt onto the surface of the bone until, to a Sigilist with Debt-Sight, it would read as a relic of the proper provenance. It would hold for one summoning, she had said. Then the surface coat would burn away. He understood now what one summoning meant. The bone's coat was visibly thinned, in places worn through to the dark beneath. It had been used. He had been the use.

The bone was, at this moment, perhaps three more handfuls of debt away from being useless.

He thought about that for a long moment.

He thought about why the cult had brought it back to the niche, and decided that the cult — Aren Mosk and his seven friends — had not brought it back at all. The cult had taken it. The cult had used it. The cult had not returned it. Someone else had put it here, in the seventh niche, after the cult had taken the genuine substitute up to the chamber and used it in the ritual. Someone had put it back.

S. had put it back.

S. had come down here after the cult had taken the substitute and before the cult — or anyone else — had thought to check the empty niche. S. had put a *second* substitute in the niche, a still-usable one, with a note pinned beside it that was addressed to Kael personally.

Why.

He looked at the bone. He looked at the note he had tucked into his collarbone-pouch. He looked, with the new sight, at the way the bone's failing coat was still — barely — alive enough to summon, and he understood,

with the sudden cold clarity of a man who has just looked at a board and seen a fork two moves out, what S. had done.

She had armed him.

She had left, in the room where she knew he would arrive, a tool he could use to summon something else.

He did not yet know what that something else was. The note had not said. The note had been very careful not to say. But the calculus was clean: S. had left a working — barely working — summoning-substitute in the bottom of a room she expected an Imp of the Eighth Ash to descend into in the wake of a failed binding, and she had not told the Brother she had done this, and she had been afraid she would be dead before he found it, and she was sorry.

Kael Veyne, eighteen inches tall, on the second day of his second life, sitting cradled in the bloody hands of a kneeling cultist, read all of that in the cushion of a niche, and felt — for the third time since waking —

something that he understood, with the same precision with which he understood everything else now, was hope.

He let himself feel it for one full second.

Then he set it down beside the other things he had set down to be considered properly later.

"Set me down," he said.

Aren Mosk set him down.

Kael walked to the center of the small round room. He sat, deliberately, on the floor. He folded his legs in the small thin way they wanted to fold and laid his tail across his knees and looked, with attention, at the Ledger.

Conditions for advancement to Stage 2 (Cinder-Imp):

1 of 5 met.

- Killed (1)
- Read your Ledger in full (pending)
- Held a debt to one named soul (pending)
- Accepted aid from one mortal (pending)
- Walked the lower Ash (pending)

The Ledger draws your attention to condition four.

Kael read this line and held very still.

Held a debt to one named soul. He had held debts since the chamber above — the death of the lead sigilist, the body of Mireille Vasc, the debts of Aren Mosk — and the Ledger had recorded each of them, and the Ledger had not, until now, considered any of them to satisfy this condition.

It had not, he understood, been about quantity. It had been about kind.

Aren Mosk's debt was held *against* him. Mireille's was held *for* her. The lead sigilist's was a settled account. None of these was the kind of debt the Ledger meant.

The note. The note in his pouch.

He had accepted, by tucking the note into the only pouch his body had, a debt *to* a named soul. Not to Mireille. To S. — a person who had taken a risk on his behalf and asked nothing in return except that he know she had done it. A person who had said *I am sorry*.

The Ledger was telling him that gratitude was a debt.

The Ledger was telling him that the only debt that progressed an Imp into a Cinder-Imp was a debt he had agreed, voluntarily, to owe.

He looked, very slowly, at Aren Mosk.

The cultist was kneeling with his hands palms-up on his thighs again, exactly as he had been kneeling in the chamber above, and his face was the slack tired face of a man who had stopped trying to predict what was happening to him. He was, Kael saw, beginning to shake. Mildly. The kind of small full-body shake that a man developed when he had been running on

adrenaline for too long and the adrenaline had run out.

"Aren Mosk," Kael said.

The cultist lifted his eyes.

"The bone in this niche is a forgery. You did not put it back, and the Brother did not put it back. Someone else did. The someone else does not love you, but she does not appear to wish you specifically dead. Do you understand what I have just told you."

"No."

"Good." Kael let the chitter of his voice soften — and was, in a clinical aside, faintly surprised that he could.

"It means that I know one thing about your circumstances that you do not. I am going to give it to you now. The Brother does not know you survived. The Brother believed all eight of you would die in the ritual or be bound by the Imp. The Brother is, at the moment, several hours from learning that one cultist walked out of that chamber alive. When he learns it, he will not be

pleased. He will not — and I want you to attend to this — be pleased that the cultist who survived was the cultist whose face the Imp can pick out of a crowd. Do you follow."

"Yes."

"The Brother will move to kill you before you can be questioned by anyone else. Including by me. You have, in the next several hours, exactly one route to survival, and the route requires that you remain attached to the only entity in this complex who has reason to keep you alive long enough to be useful. That entity is sitting on the floor in front of you. Do you understand."

"Yes."

"Good." Kael, in the small thin way of his small thin body, allowed himself the smallest expression he had so far produced — not quite a smile, the new face would not yet make one, but a small narrowing of the eyes that might, on a less unfamiliar face, have been one. "Then we agree."

Aren Mosk, who had not in fact been offered any agreement, nodded as though he had been offered one.

Kael turned back to the niche. He stood up. He walked, a little steadier this time, to the base of the wall. "Lift me again. Gently. I am going to take the bone."

Aren Mosk lifted him.

Kael, very carefully, took the finger bone from its black cushion.

It was lighter than he had expected. It was warmer than he had expected. The Debt-Sight, at the moment of contact, gave him a third piece of information he had not had before:

Bone identified: distal phalanx, left little finger.
Source: a saint of the Glass Choir, name unrecorded.
Authentic relic, coated by another hand to read as the
relic of Saint Aelirhen of Six Tongues.

This coat will hold for one further summoning, if you are
willing to pay the cost.
The cost is not yet costed.
The Ledger advises you to ask before you pay.

Saint of the Glass Choir, Kael thought. He filed the phrase. The Ledger had mentioned the Glass Choir before, in a context he had not yet attended to: the second of his romanceable-cast — no, that was not the Ledger, that was not the Ledger, that was a thought that was not his and had no business being there, that was — that was the *outline*. Kael, with the small sharp clarity of a man hearing the wrong voice in his own head, paused.

He did not know what he had just thought.

He held very still and turned, with great care, his attention inward.

He could feel — and this was new, this was something he had not felt above the hatch — a second pressure in his small skull. Not the Ledger. The Ledger sat behind his right eye, calm, steady, a second heartbeat. This was somewhere else. This was at the back of his head, near the base. A small humming, almost a tuning fork, almost a thought he had not had.

Cognitive Strain, he thought, with the recognition of a man who has read the table of contents and is now meeting chapter three.

He set the small humming down, very gently, where he set down most things, and he made his attention deliberately empty for one breath, two, three.

The humming receded.

"All right," he said aloud, to nobody in particular, in the small chittering voice that was, perhaps, less wrong now than it had been an hour ago.

He looked again at the bone in his small purple hand.

"Set me down."

Aren Mosk set him down.

Kael stood in the center of the small round room with the bone of an unnamed saint of the Glass Choir clasped between two clawed fingers, and the note from S. tucked against his collarbone, and the small humming receding at the base of his skull, and he understood — with the cold pleasure of a man assembling a chessboard from pieces other people had abandoned — that he had been given, in the last twenty minutes, four new things.

One, a tool.

Two, an ally — a distant one, anonymous, possibly already dead, but a real one.

Three, the knowledge that another Candidate had been here before him.

Four, a route up: he now knew that the cult's seven niches had once held seven anchors, that S. had

replaced one of them, and that the other six anchors — *real* ones, ungilded, the original scattered parts of a saint — were elsewhere in this complex. The Ledger, when he turned his attention to the question, would not yet answer where. But he could ask Aren Mosk, who knew where the other six niches were, because Aren Mosk had visited at least one of them, and Aren Mosk had no further interest in keeping secrets.

He had, in other words, found in this small round room not merely his next move. He had found the shape of the rest of the chapter of his life that began at the bottom of the hatch and ended at the door of whatever city was above his head.

He thought, with mild surprise: I have a plan.

He had not had a plan an hour ago.

He looked at Aren Mosk.

"Get up," he said. "We have six more niches to find."

Aren Mosk got up. He picked up the book. He picked up the water-skin. He set his shoulders. His grey eyes, which had been the eyes of a tired animal, were beginning — Kael saw, with a small precise interest — to be something else. Not the eyes of a believer; the cultist had spent his belief. But not the eyes of an animal anymore either. Aren Mosk had, perhaps, somewhere in the last twenty minutes, found a thing he wanted to live long enough to see.

"Imp," he said.

Kael did not turn. "Yes."

"What is your name."

Kael was, briefly, surprised.

He had not, until that moment, considered the question of his name. The Ledger had recorded him as Kael Veyne. He was Kael Veyne. He had been Kael Veyne in the stairwell. But Kael Veyne had been a Tokyo actuary with a knee that gave at three strides and a

thirty-one-year-old's sloppy posture, and the small clawed thing in the round reliquary at the bottom of the hatch was not, by any honest accounting, that man any longer. He was Kael Veyne the way an account was a person. The name was the title on the page.

He thought about whether to answer. He thought about whether the answer mattered. He thought about whether the name belonged to him, now, or had become — like the body — a thing he was wearing.

He gave Aren Mosk the answer because Aren Mosk had asked the right question at the right time, and a man who asked the right question deserved an answer.

"Kael," he said. "Kael Veyne. You may use it. Sparingly."

Aren Mosk nodded. He did not smile. He did not bow. He did the thing that, of all the things he might have done, was the only one Kael respected: he made, very small, very tight, with the bloody knuckles of his right hand against the center of his bony chest, the bow that

the Tannev city watch made to a magistrate they did not like but expected to obey. A gesture of formal address, between unequals, with no warmth in it and no insolence either. The bow of a man who had stopped being a cultist and had not yet decided what to be instead.

Kael accepted it.

He walked toward the arch. The tail, behind him, came along of its own intelligence. Aren Mosk followed, the book against his chest, the water-skin slung at his back, and his bad knee no worse than it had been on the way in.

At the arch Kael paused.

He looked back into the small round reliquary — at the seven niches, at the six emptied of all but their stale glow and the seventh now properly empty too, at the small black cushion that had held the bone and the note, at the round dome of the ceiling and the curve of the cold dressed wall — and he understood, with a

small precise stillness, that he was looking at the first place in this world he was ever going to remember.

It was, he thought, an odd place to begin to be a person.

He turned and walked through the arch into the lower passage.

The Ledger, behind his eye, did not comment.

It was, he understood, still listening.

And somewhere behind him, in the back of his small skull, in the quiet space the humming had occupied and then left, a single second sentence drifted up — quiet, neutral, almost gentle, in a voice that was almost his own and not quite —

Stage two condition four: met.

— end of Chapter Three —